



Whirlybirds

de Havilland/Cierva C24 Autogiro UK 1931

Body is 20ft (6.1 m)
in length

Focke-Wulf Fa61 Germany 1936

In 1939, when
few helicopters
had taken off, an
Fa61 climbed to
11,240 ft
(2,436 m).

SNCASE Liore et Oliver LeO C302 France 1939

Radial engine
powers propeller
to move autogiro
forward

Tail rotor guard
prevents blades from
striking the ground
and snapping

Drive shaft connects
engine to tail rotor

One of two fuel tanks,
each of which can hold
21.4 gal (81 liters)

Three-bladed main
rotor with diameter
of 37ft 8in (11.5 m)

Tail rotor

Sikorsky R-4 USA 1942

Landing skids could be replaced
with floats for landing on water

With long, thin, wing-shaped blades whizzing around, it is no surprise that the first autogiros and helicopters got the nickname *whirlybirds*. These versatile craft first came into their own in the 1930s and 1940s.

Autogiros, such as the **Cierva C24**, use a main rotor for lift, but also have a propeller at the front to provide thrust. This gave the C24 a top speed of 110mph (177km/h). The experimental **Focke-Wulf Fa61** came with two sets of rotors, to increase lift, but only two were ever made.